

TROPHY

Meller Survives the Late Surge

Gregg Williams and Stuart Neumann both closed with the best net rounds of their careers, but Henry Meller's early-week cushion proved just enough to see out the TEG 7 Trophy.

Henry Meller won the 2014 TEG Trophy at Praia D'El Rey. He led after every round of the final day and took it by 7 on net-versus-par. What the margin conceals is that he spent the last afternoon being hunted.

Overnight, the cushion had been 15 shots. That is not a lead. That is a moat with a drawbridge and a fortnight of provisions. By the finish it was 7.

The chief threat came from Gregg Williams, who at one point trailed by 20 and appeared

to have accepted it. He then posted a personal-best -12, also his best-ever gross round at +20, and closed to within 7. Stuart Neumann matched that gap from 17 back, having repaired a third round of +4 with a -12 of his own. David Mullin, separately confirmed as Green Jacket winner, came from 15 behind to finish 8 adrift.

None of it was enough. Meller's lead never actually changed hands, which is the only sentence in this section that will comfort him. A day that began as a procession ended with three men closing on him at once.

AT A GLANCE
TROPHY WINNER Henry Meller
GREEN JACKET David Mullin
WOODEN SPOON Alex Baker

ROUND NET VP
GW -12 SN -12 DM -9 HM -2 JB -1 AB 0
ROUND GROSS
DM +10 SN +11 GW +20 JB +20 HM +23 AB +36

AFTER R4 • TROPHY
HM -31 GW -24 SN -24 DM -23 JB -13 AB -5
AFTER R4 • GREEN JACKET
DM +53 SN +68 HM +69 JB +71 GW +104 AB +139

DAVID MULLIN

Mullin Breaks the Course Record

A triple bogey at the 10th barely dented a round that turned out to be the best gross card played all week.

David Mullin shot 83 gross at Praia D'El Rey in round 4. It is a new course record, beating the previous best of 84 from six prior visits. It is also the second-best gross round in TEG history to date, ten shots better than par. That is the headline, and it deserves to stand undisturbed for one sentence.

The round was not without incident. Mullin bogeyed the 9th, then ran up a triple bogey at the par-5 10th, which is a curious way to enter the record books. He stopped the bleeding with a birdie at the 11th. That launched a run of four shots gained to par across holes 11 to 13, following an earlier stretch from the 4th to the 8th in which he had gained five. A double bogey at the short

14th then ended his run of pars, as if to remind everyone where he plays his golf.

The 83 beat his own previous best at the course, 89, by six shots. It stands as his best score there through this TEG. He remained the Green Jacket leader, his overall advantage narrowing slightly to 15.

WOODEN SPOON

Alex Baker Wraps Up the Spoon

Two quintuple bogeys either side of a rare purple patch summed up a tournament Alex Baker's Wooden Spoon was never really in danger of leaving.

Alex Baker's final round at Praia D'El Rey confirmed what the preceding days had been patiently explaining to him. The TEG 7 Wooden Spoon was his. He began the round eight shots adrift of safety and finished exactly eight adrift, which suggests a certain consistency of purpose.

The trouble started at the short 3rd with a quadruple bogey 7. It matured into a pair of quintuple bogey 9s, first at the 6th, then again at the 16th. In between came a strange pocket of composure. A birdie at the 14th halted a run of bogeys and doubles, and across three holes from the 13th he gained five shots against par. For a moment he was a golfer.

It changed nothing. The round did yield one consolation, his best score yet at the course this TEG, a distinction of the kind normally awarded to the least-damaged car in the wreck. The Spoon was his for the taking, and he took it.

JON BAKER

Two Holes Undo Jon Baker

A sextuple bogey and a quadruple bogey in successive holes capped a slow-motion slide from early pace-setter to also-ran.

Jon Baker's Sunday at Praia D'El Rey began quietly. His opening round of the tournament had already put him second in the TEG 7 Trophy and first in the TEG 7 Green Jacket. He then played holes 2 through 5 without dropping a single gross shot, gaining five strokes to par. It looked like the work of a man who had solved something.

Then came the 10th. A sextuple bogey 11 on the par-5, his worst hole of the tournament. He walked to the short 11th and made a quadruple bogey 7. Two holes. No survivors.

The standings absorbed the news without sentiment. Baker slipped from second to fifth in the Trophy race and from first to fourth in the Green Jacket, a three-place fade in both, having led the way after round one. Round four at Praia D'El Rey turned from foundation to rubble inside two holes.

RECORDS & PERSONAL BESTS

Notable achievements: TEG 7, Round 4

TEG RECORDS
— David Mullin's +10 (gross) is the 2nd-best Gross round in TEG history to date
COURSE RECORDS
— David Mullin's 83 at Praia D'El Rey — a new course record, beating 84; 6 earlier rounds there

PERSONAL BESTS
— Gregg Williams posts a personal-best round: -12
— Gregg Williams posts a personal-best Gross round: +20
— David Mullin's 5-hole "Pars or Better" streak is a personal best (previous 4), at T07 R4 H4 to T07 R4 H8
RARE FEATS
— Jon Baker runs up an 11 (+6) at the 10th — his career-worst on a par-5